



Dead Or Alive 4

impressed. The controller is compact and feels like it's been in your hand forever. The left analog stick is *exactly* where it should be—you don't need to stretch your thumb at all. While this is a slightly alarming break if you're used to the PS2, you'll soon realise that the chances of your thumb fatiguing after the inevitable long hours of gaming are much lower with such an arrangement. The sticks are quite loose to the touch—they don't offer as much tactile feedback as those of the PS2, but they're nice and responsive nonetheless.

The analog triggers at either side are well-placed, but they do have a larger dead zone than expected—kicking into action only after being depressed more than half-way. The D-Pad is probably the only negative about the controller—it's slippery at times and is generally unimpressive.

Controllers are available in both wired and wireless flavours (which run on standard AA batteries), depending on how much you're willing to cough up for your 360. Wireless controllers bond with the main unit by a press of a button on both the controller and the box, and have a ridiculously large range: unless your living room is the size of a cinema hall, it's unlikely you'll be facing any problems with them.

Play Me

We had four titles to test the system with—*Project Gotham Racing* (PGR) 3, *Dead Or Alive 4*, *FIFA World Cup Soccer*, and *Kameo: Elements of Power*. When we fired it up on a regular TV, the results were, well, underwhelming. Granted, of course, that the 360 churns out frames with more enthusiasm than dentists brush their teeth with, but on an ordinary TV, the result doesn't elicit many oohs and/or aahs. Hook it up to a wide-screen HDTV (ours was Samsung), set the resolution to 1080i, and different tunes are sung. Clearly, no unnecessarily tall claims have been made about the 360 being optimised for HDTV—the games look exquisite! This marked difference comes with a flip side, though. If you already own a console but don't own an HD-capable TV, you might want to dip into those pockets a lot more for an HDTV to get the most out of the 360—or just stick with your current console.

As for the multi-core Xenon CPU from IBM, coupled with the custom-built graphics chip from ATI, they come together to dish out frame-rates smoother than well-buttered ice rinks. In

The latest in Team Ninja's series of combat games for hormonally-charged teenagers is the first of its kind to really show off the Xbox 360's abilities. It's more than just a button-mashing fight fest—it's a button-mashing fight fest with some very scantily clad women who satisfy just about any fantasy you may have had as a teen and still might have today. Hormonal stimulation aside, there's a lot about this game that is quite impressive.

First on the block is the level design—all fighting arenas have been designed in intricate detail, even paying attention to bystanders who have absolutely no role to play in the fight. Environments are huge and immersive, and you'll never find one of those "invisible walls" that confine you to a particular area for gameplay.

The gameplay itself is far beyond punching random buttons—it'll get you past the easier levels, but you'll find yourself stuck soon enough if you don't learn the complex counter-attack system that this game sports. It's not as easy to figure out as we'd like, though—patience is the key here. The game shines as a multi-player—hook up all four controllers and prepare yourself for endless hours of team vs. team fights.

There's only one thing about this game that contributes to its success—the women. Each one is built with



one or more unrealistic male fantasies in mind, and the 360's brilliant graphics bring them to life like nothing else could. It's an ordeal to look beyond that and actually analyse the game underneath the game—and unless you're going to review it for a magazine, it's an ordeal you won't undertake.

For all it's worth, there's even a story to this game, and each of the 16 characters you can play as has a different part in a much bigger tale. All that is utter nonsense—the so-called story is little more than an excuse to unlock videos of characters, featuring them in all their near-naked glory.

This title is sure to fly off the shelves into the hands of young teenagers, but is liable to fly back just as fast in the hands of some very cheesed-off parents.

